

TURNING IDEAS INTO IMPACT

A conversation with Rayhaan Survé,
Chairman of the Survé Family Office and Founder of iAccelerate South Africa

In a world where young people are increasingly shaping the future of innovation, iAccelerate South Africa (iASA) stands out as a movement redefining entrepreneurship. Founded by Rayhaan Survé, Chairman of the Survé Family Office, iASA equips young changemakers with the skills, mentorship and mindset to turn ideas into impact.

As the world looks to South Africa for the G20 Summit, we sat down with Rayhaan to discuss how iASA is empowering the next generation of leaders, ensuring a more inclusive and resilient Global South.

What inspired you to bring the iXperiment model from Romania to South Africa?

What inspired me about iXperiment was seeing the incredible impact it had on young people and the fact that it was youth-led. The challenges the team in Romania were tackling felt very similar to those faced by young South Africans. The realisation that opportunity and struggle often mirror each other globally really motivated me. Entrepreneurship education has the unique power to unlock potential, and I wanted to bring that impact home. Fortunately, my fiancée, Mara Steiu, founded iXperiment ten years ago. Seeing the programme's impact through her eyes, I asked if she'd support me in launching it here. She was thrilled to see it expand to South Africa. That's how it began, and today, iAccelerate SA empowers teenagers in public schools to think and act like entrepreneurs.

How would you describe iAccelerate's core philosophy – what makes it more than "just another entrepreneurship programme"?

Honestly, we're not trying to be extraordinary, just deeply intentional. Our philosophy is simple: empower people so they can empower others. That creates a ripple effect where individual transformation builds collective impact. Our goal isn't only to develop entrepreneurs but to nurture changemakers who uplift their communities and, eventually, the continent. What truly sets iAccelerate apart is what happens after the programme. Once students pitch their businesses and complete the four-month journey, they leave with a lasting network. Every two months, we host Community Days, bringing alumni together for workshops, mentoring and networking. At our last session, we held a LinkedIn workshop and one-on-one mentor meetings to discuss students' life goals. iAccelerate isn't just a programme, it's a lifelong community. The best part? Every graduate said they want to mentor the next cohort. For me, that's real success, impact that multiplies.

Can you share a story or example of a participant whose project embodies the spirit of iAccelerate?

There were many, but one that stands out is Ukukhanya Wellness Organisation, focused on mental health. The students, aged 14 to 17, noticed how gender-based violence and mental health weren't openly discussed in their communities. So, they created safe spaces where people could talk about their struggles through storytelling and film. It's young people recognising a social challenge and deciding to solve it themselves. Entrepreneurship can take many forms, and for them to lead that kind of initiative at such a young age is incredible.

Many youth programmes focus on skills; iAccelerate focuses on mindset. How do you cultivate that shift from job-seeking to changemaking?

Most entrepreneurship programmes focus on venture building, and that's important, but it's only part of what we do. Our goals are threefold. First, we build an entrepreneurial mindset: confidence, creativity, and problem-solving that students can apply anywhere, in school, work, or life. Second, we prepare them for the next steps, like job interviews or university applications, by helping them build resilience and adaptability. And third, we support venture creation, guiding them to turn ideas into real businesses.

If at the end of the programme only a few ventures continue, but every student walks away thinking differently, confident, resourceful, solution-oriented, that's a win. Our goal is lifelong impact, not short-term success.